# VOWELS

# Vowels

- Peter McCarthy states:
- **“A pure vowel is one for which the organs of speech remain in a given position for a time. A Diphthong is a vowel sound consisting of a deliberate and intentional glide”**

# Description of Vowel Sounds

- The tongue can assume a large number of positions during the articulation of vowel sounds, the upper surface of the main body of the tongue is usually convex.
- And some part of the tongue – **the front, back or centre-** is raised in the direction of the roof of the mouth
- **i)Front Vowels:** are those during the articulation of which the front the tongue raised in the direction of the hard palate. However, the space between the front of the tongue and the palate should be sufficient for the air to escape without any friction.
- The **Front Vowels in the English words** : **bee**, **bid**, **bed** and **bad**, as in

**/i:/, /i/, /e/, /æ/**

**Front Vowels**: **/i:/ – cream, seen** (long high front spread vowel) **/i/ – bit, silly** (short high front spread vowel) **/e/ – bet, head** (short mid front spread vowel) **/æ/ – cat, dad** (short low front spread vowel).

# Front

1. /iː/ (long high front spread vowel).
   Examples: cream, seen, sea, see,
2. /ɪ/ (short high front spread vowel)
   Examples: bit, silly, pin, sit
3. /e/ (short mid front spread vowel)
   Examples: bet, head, get, beg
4. /æ/ (Short low front spread vowel)

Examples: cat, dad, act, fact

# Description of Vowel Sounds cont…

- **ii) Back Vowels:** are those during the articulation of which the back of the tongue is raised in the direction of the soft palate in such a way that there is sufficiently wide gap between them for the air to escape without friction.
- The ***Back vowels*** in English words:
- **cart, cot, caught, push** and **pool** are examples.
  **/ɑː/, /ɒ/, / ɔː/, /u/ /u:/**
- **Back Vowels**: **/u:/ – boot, glue** (long hight back rounded vowel). / **u ˆ**/ – **put, full** (short high back rounded vowel). /¿ – corn, born (long mid back rounded vowel) / **ɒ** / – **dog, rotten** (short low back rounded vowel) **/a:/ – hard, far** (long low back spread vowel)

# Back Vowels

8. /uː/ long high back rounded vowel
   Examples: boot, glue, moon
9. /ʊ/ short high back rounded vowel
   examples: put, soot, would, wood
10. /ɔː/ long mid back rounded vowel
    examples: corn, born, horse
11. /ɒ/ short low back slightly rounded vowel
    examples: pot, dog, plot, what, not
12. /ɑː/ long low back spread vowel
    examples: hard, far, car, farm

# Description of Vowel Sounds cont…

- **iii) Central Vowels**: Vowels may be produced by raising the **centre of the tongue** in the direction of that part of the roof of the mouth where the hard palate and soft palate meet . These vowels are called central vowels.
- **Central Vowels are: earn , cup** and **heard**
- **/ə/ , /ʌ / & / ɜ:/**
- **Central Vowels**: /ɜ:/- **burn, firm, earn, stern** (long mid central spread vowel) / **/ə/ /– about, clever, again** (short mid central spread vowel); this is called schwa. **/ʌ / – cut, nut, hut, bus** (Short low front spread vowel).

- **Conclusion:** Vowels can be classified into **front, back** and **central** taking into consideration the part of the tongue that is highest in the mouth during their articulation.

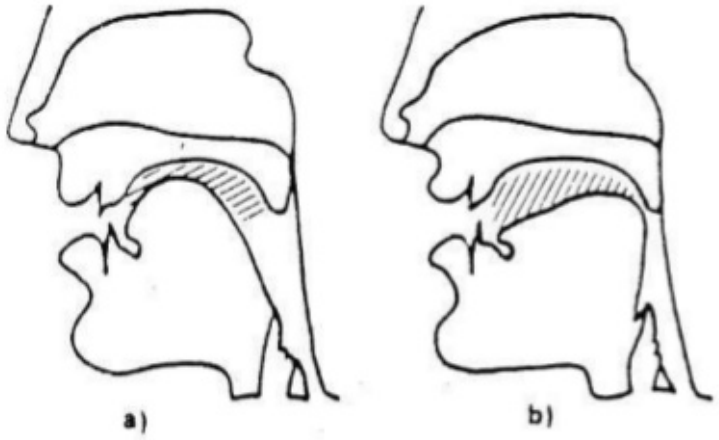
# Central

5. /ɜː/ long mid central spread vowel.
   examples: earth, burn, firm
6. /ə/ short mid central spread vowel.
   examples: about, clever, ago, teacher
7. /ʌ/ Short low central spread vowel.
   examples: cut, nut,
   note: the vowel sound in not and what is the not the same as that in cut and nut

# Position of Tongue

The next figure gives you two examples of tongue position:

a) is an example of the front of the tongue being at the highest.
b) it is the back of the tongue which is nearest to the palate.

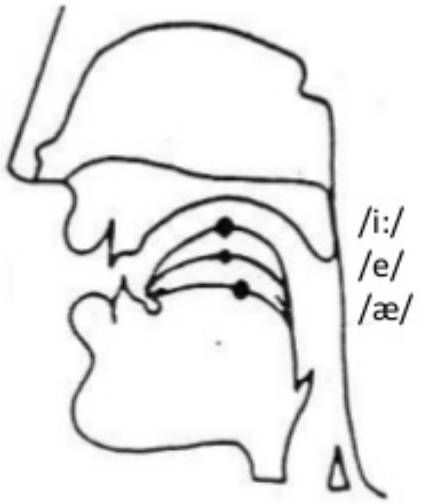



(a) front and (b) back. (Thomas 1976:56)

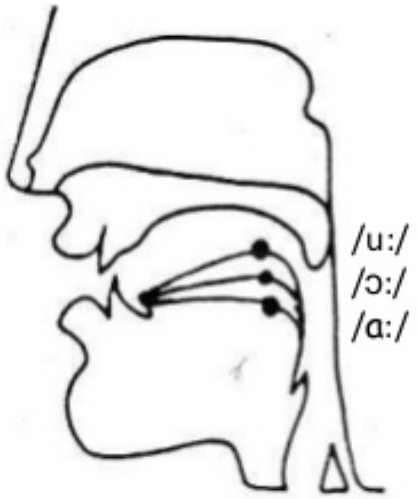
# Posit

For example /ɜ/ is front and /ɔ:/ is back, and /æ/ front, /ɑ:/ back. There are also vowels in between front and back, called **central**, namely /ɜ:/, /ə/, /ʌ/ as in /wɜ:d/, /fɔ:wəd/, /mʌd/ (*word*, *forward*, *mud*). /ɜ:/ for instance is between /e/ and /ɔ:/, as can be seen from /bed,/ /bɜ:d, bɔ:d], (*bed*, *bird*, *board*).

To give an accurate account of tongue position one has to combine height of the tongue and part of the tongue involved.




a) height position for front vowels




b) height position for back vowels

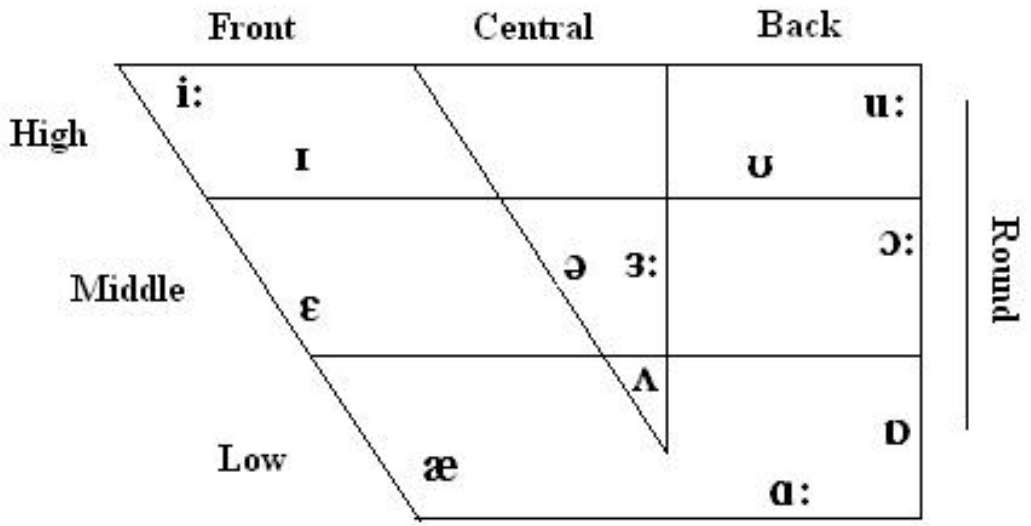
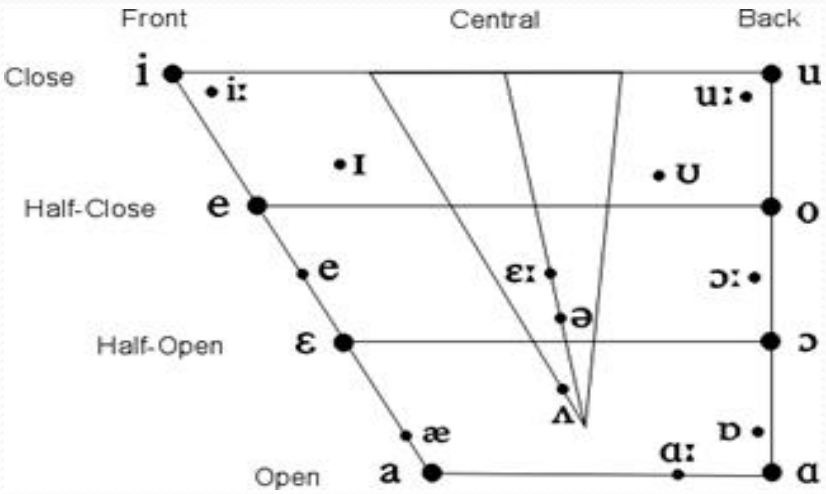



Fig 1. English vowels chart

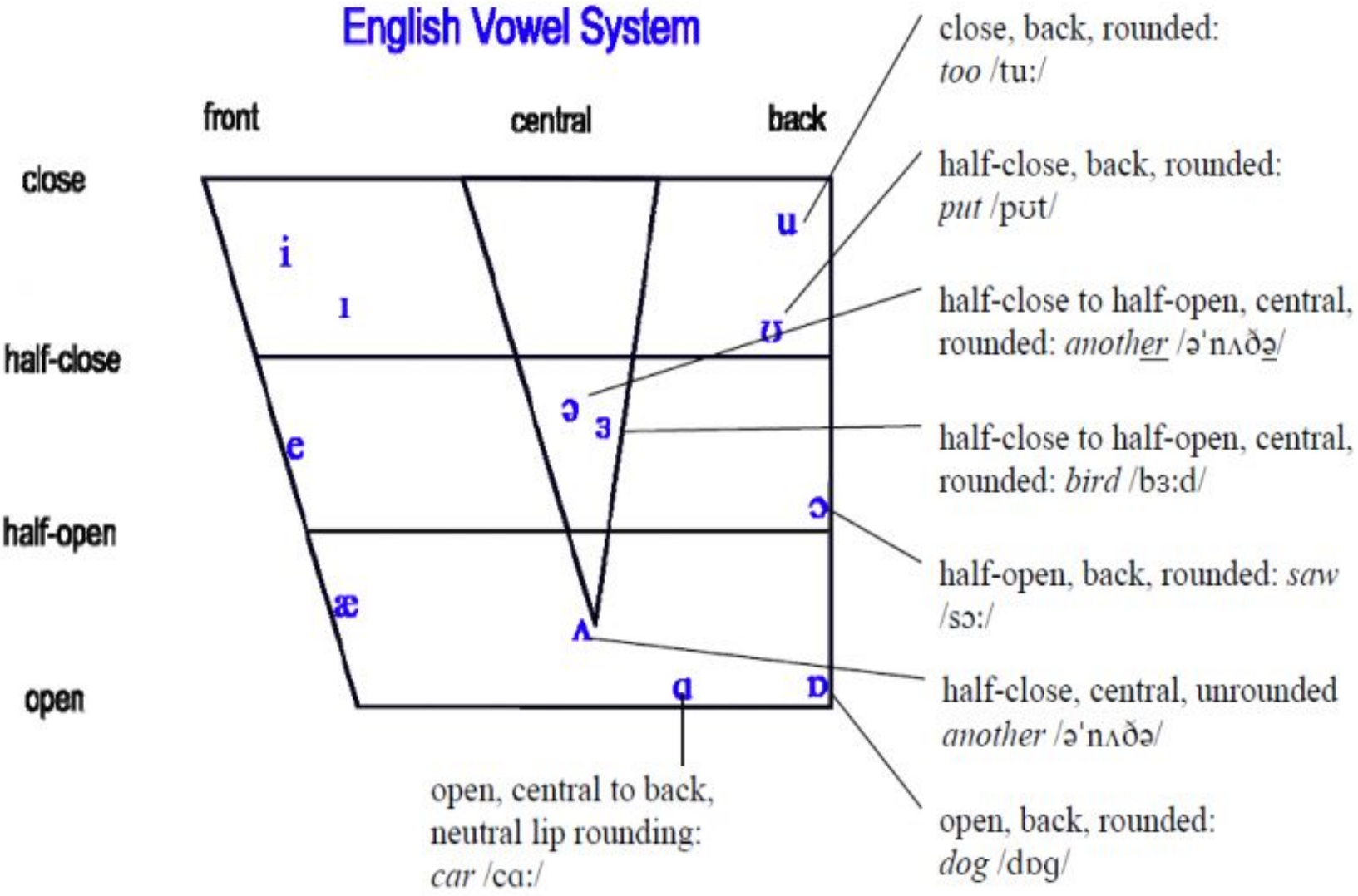
# Cardinal Vowels

- 1)front close unrounded-/**i/- fin, in, win, sit, bit,**
- 2)front half –close unrounded- /**e/-eight, ate**
- 3)front half –open unrounded-/**ə /-about**
- 4)front open unrounded-**/a/-ask, arm**
- 5)back open unrounded-/**a:/-start, cart,art**
- 6)back half-open rounded- **/ɔ /-cot,on**
- 7)back half-close rounded- **/ɔ :/- caught**
- 8) back close rounded-/**u/- pull, full, good,wood,put**

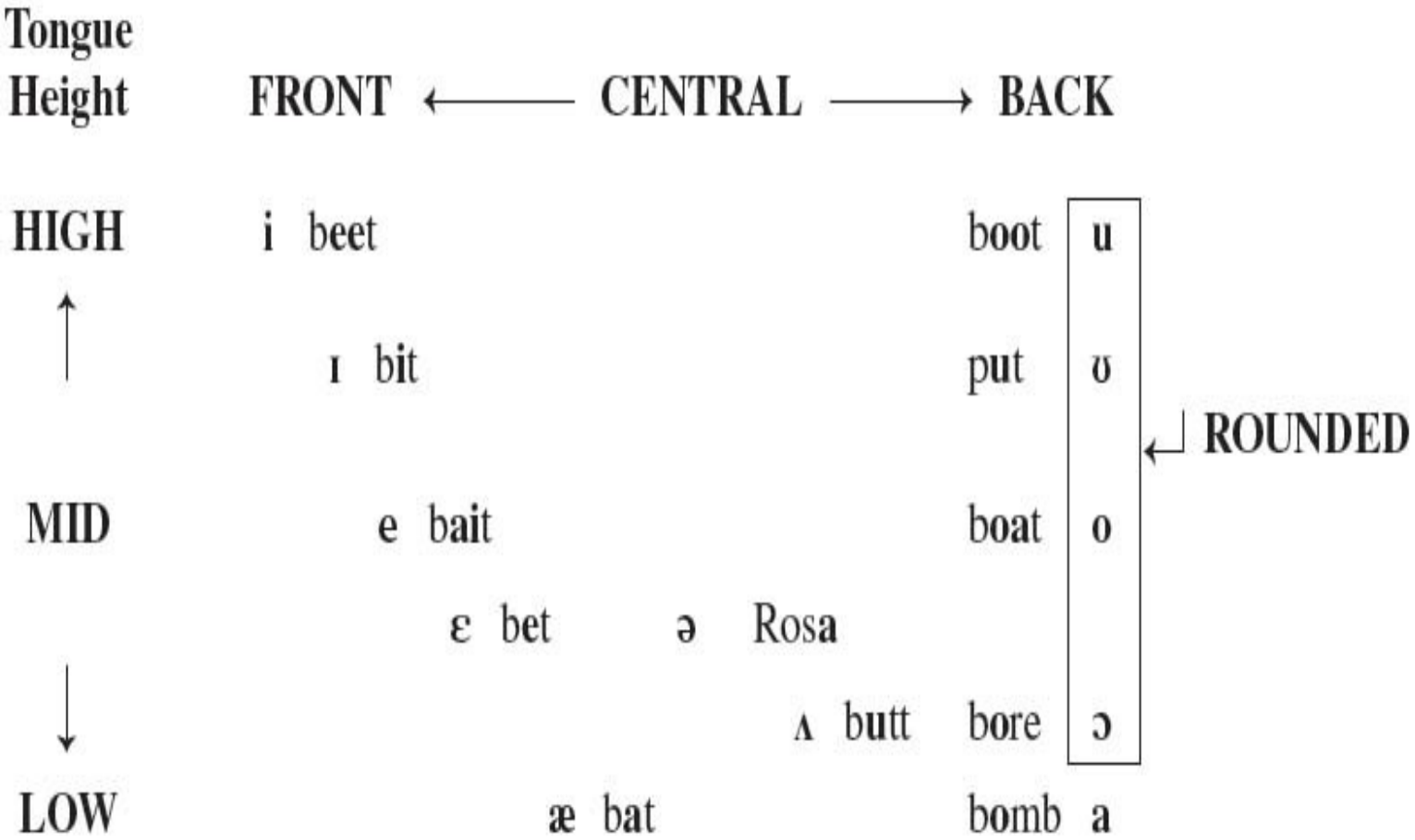
# Vowel position



# Cardinal vowels



## Part of the Tongue Involved



# Questions?

Describe the underlined vowel sound

1. Glue
2. Mother
3. Corn
4. Cream
5. Sit
6. Act
7. car

# References


- http://www.linguisticsweb.org/
- https://neoenglish.wordpress.com